Reported speech and conditionals in academic texts

Understand it

Academic texts often report other people's ideas with verbs like claim, argue and suggest. In Yes / No / Not Given questions you must decide whether the WRITER agrees, not whether someone in the text agrees.

Reported speech moves tenses back, and reporting verbs have their own patterns (suggest + -ing, advise + someone + to).

The rules

- Reporting verbs: claim, argue, suggest, state, believe, point out, admit, deny. The writer reports someone else's opinion.
- Reported speech shifts the tense back: She said, 'It is hard' = She said it was hard.
- Conditionals in texts show possibility: If emissions fall, the climate may stabilize.
- In Yes / No / Not Given, the question asks about the writer's view, not the view the writer reports.

All the words and forms you need

Neutral reporting	say · state · report · explain · describe · note · mention
Opinion	argue · claim · believe · maintain · insist · contend
Agree / disagree	admit · acknowledge · accept · concede · deny · reject · dispute · question
Patterns	suggest + -ing / that · recommend + -ing · advise + sb + to · warn + sb + not to · deny + -ing
Tense shift	is → was · will → would · can → could · has done → had done
Writer's own view signals	I · we · in my view · clearly · surprisingly · unfortunately

Where you use it

Reading: Yes / No / Not Given: who holds the opinion? The writer or someone else?

Listening: Speakers report what others said: The tutor said we should finish by Friday.

Writing: Refer to sources: According to the report, ...

Speaking: My teacher told me that ...

More examples

- Some experts claim that the method works, but the evidence is weak. (The writer doubts it.)
- The author admits that the sample was small.
- She suggested taking a different route.

- The doctor advised him to rest.
- He said that he would call later.
- Critics deny that the policy has failed.

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ She said me that she was tired.	✓ She told me that she was tired.
✗ He suggested to take a break.	✓ He suggested taking a break.
✗ If emissions will fall, ...	✓ If emissions fall, ...

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. What did your teacher tell you last lesson?
2. What advice did your parents give you about studying?
3. Some people say money brings happiness. Do you agree?
4. Report a news story you heard recently.

Writing practice

Report: 'We will open a new school next year,' the mayor said. / 'You should revise every day,' my teacher said.

Practice

1. Report: 'I am tired,' he said.

2. Report: 'We will help,' they said.

3. Choose: She (said / told) me the news.

4. Whose opinion? Some experts claim that X; the writer disagrees. Does the writer say X is true?

5. Correct: He suggested to leave.

6. Complete: If taxes ___ (rise), spending may fall.

Answers

1. He said he was tired.
2. They said they would help.
3. told
4. No
5. He suggested leaving.
6. rise